27 DECEMBER 2021

INDIA | 81,906 ACTIVE CASES | 4,80,290 DEATHS | 141 CRORE VACCINE DOSES

WORLD | 23,84,131 ACTIVE CASES | 54,23,142 DEATHS | 450 CRORE VACCINE DOSES

A few weeks before the year-end holidays, South Africa reported a sharp rise in COVID-19 cases owing to a new variant (B.1.1.29), which later came to known as Omicron, which showed significantly increased transmissibility as compared with other variants, including Delta.[16] In a matter of days, it was detected in several other countries in the world, leading to waves of infections around the holiday season. Very quickly, many countries closed borders for 'at-risk' nations, where the variant was believed to have spread rapidly. Scientists scrambled to figure out whether the new variant caused symptoms which were different from the previous variants, whether they were mild or severe and, most importantly, if the variant evaded the immunity generated by vaccines and previous infections. Early evidence suggested, providing much relief that Omicron resulted in only mild illness resembling that of a common cold in folks who were fully vaccinated. Cough, fatigue, tiredness and a runny nose seemed to be the most rampant symptoms generated. Vaccine manufacturers were quick to come out with supporting research on the effectiveness of their vaccines against Omicron and the need for booster doses to 'boost immunity' for better protection.[17] Even as countries in the developed world began to offer booster doses, many countries in the developing world remained without vaccines. The vaccine inequity was glaring. So disturbing was this hyper-nationalism of boosting its citizens and closing borders to at-risk nations including South Africa that the WHO chief announced that, 'Blanket booster programs are likely to prolong the pandemic, rather than ending it, by diverting supply to countries that already have high levels of vaccination coverage, giving the virus more opportunity to spread and mutate.' He added that, 'Vaccine inequality will allow the pandemic to continue. Countries with low access to initial doses of the vaccine will become breeding grounds for mutant variants of the virus.'[18]

Having been on the receiving end of low vaccine dose availability and discriminatory behaviour from nations such as blanket bans for our citizens